NEW YORK · JANUARY 1882

Ellen Sardy

Caught in Simpson, Crawford & Simpson's Sixth Avenue store with three pairs of stockings and five pieces of silk. Her lawyer admitted the theft and pleaded that she had been 'of weak mind'.

KLEPTOMANIA

She went free.

LONDON · MAY 1895

Hannah Wilson & Ann Hanstead

Caught at a City silk warehouse with eighty-six yards of silk rolled under a skirt. Wilson told the court she was 'a respectable woman, of Hackney'. No doctor spoke for them; both had a previous conviction.

THEFT

Guilty. Three years' penal servitude.

A Paris newspaper of the period suggested defining a thief as 'a kind of kleptomaniac, but of the lower social class' — and a kleptomaniac as 'a kind of thief, but of the better class'.

Two verdicts (comparison) · *Made for this exhibition · Based on Elaine S. Abelson, 'The Invention of Kleptomania', Signs 15:1 (1989), citing the New York Times, 18 Jan 1882; and the Proceedings of the Old Bailey, trial t18950520-454*